

Internet. With the portable digital player around, all you need is a USB transfer cable and a regular supply of batteries.

To download music from the Internet, log on to a Web site that offers free MP3s, such as www.mp3.com, or www.amazon.com, and download songs by independent artists. Or, if your player supports the AAC format, you can pay for, download and listen to high-quality songs from the iTunes (www.itunes.com) Web site. Software such as Musicmatch and RealPlayer also let you listen to online radio stations that feature top-of-the-charts artists, and let you download MP3s for a small fee.

Of course, you can also use P2P applications and download just about any song you want—but this is illegal. That said, let's check out some software that will get your player rocking.



Apacer AP510

The Essentials

The friendly Windows Media Player installs along with a default installation of Windows. Windows Media Player is a complete suite that will help you organise your music as well as sync it with your portable player.

WMP 10 is the latest avatar of the Windows Media Series (*find it on the Digit December DVD*), and by far the most accessible—the only downside is that it can only be used in Windows XP. The clearly marked tabs on the top let you arrange your songs using the Library function, and sync your songs with the portable player using the Sync function. If you want to delete a song from the portable player, click on the song that you want to delete, and click the cross button at the top.

We recommend using Windows Media 9 series on machines running Windows 98 or ME, and Windows Media Player 10 on machines running Windows XP.

One thing the Windows Media 9 series does not support is direct ripping of CDs to MP3s: you will need to install an additional codec, available for a price, from either Cyberlink or InterVideo to get MP3 ripping functionality into Windows Media Player 9. On the other hand, WMP10 comes with inbuilt MP3 ripping functionality.

But MP3 is not the only option you have; you can rip your CDs into the WMA format, and you can set the bitrate at which the CD will be ripped. Generally, ripping at 128 Kbps in WMA format is more than enough for listening pleasure, and results in a smaller filesize.

Freeware CD rippers such as EAC (Exact Audio Copy), Musicmatch Jukebox and dBPowerAmp are also available to burn CDs. Although the free version of Musicmatch jukebox is crippled—you can only burn and rip CDs at a speed of 5X. EAC is by far the best in terms of high-quality CD ripping. The only extra software you will need to download to use EAC to rip directly to MP3 is the LAME codec, which is available for free on the Internet. dBPowerAmp, on the other hand, does a blazing fast job of CD ripping to MP3s, at any bitrate you specify, and is recommended for a “no-hassles” CD-ripping experience.

Tagging Your Music Using ID3 Tags

After you have ripped your collection of Audio CDs, most of the ripped audio tracks on your computer will be labelled with names such as Track01.mp3 or Track01.wma. On a portable player, it would be difficult to figure out what song is playing if all of them are labelled Track01, Track02, and so on. ID3 tagging of songs will not only help you overcome this mess, but also to organise your collection on and off your portable player.

ID3 tagging, basically, helps you organise your songs. The information you can include is title, artist, album, year, genre and a comment field. This was in ID3 tag version 1.1, and the drawback of this version was that it was limited to a maximum of 30 characters. So if you had to

How We Tested

We kept the process of testing the portable digital music players very simple, so that it not only helped in judging the quality of the player, but also allowed the scores to reflect the real-life performance of the player.

The test system we used consisted of a Pentium 4 3.2 GHz running on a MSI NEO P-875 motherboard with onboard sound and a GeForce4 Ti 4600 video card. Two Corsair TwinX 256MB memory modules running at 400 MHz provided the system memory, while a Seagate 120 GB SATA hard drive was loaded with Windows XP Professional with Service Pack 1 (for USB 2.0 functionality).

In the Features test, we included all the features that a player could possibly have, including storage capacity, FM recording, USB 2.0, audio formats

supported, etc. Features that were unique to a player were given extra points.

In the Ergonomics and Ease of Use sections, we allotted the most weight to the interface and the intuitiveness of the button placement on the player. This was followed by the earphone comfort factor, which is one of the most important factors when you are looking for a portable digital music player. Build quality was another criterion we looked at: players should be able to handle a fair amount of wear and tear.

The Performance section included playing selected audio files on the players and transferring data to the player. If the player supported recording, we also recorded a small paragraph at default settings to check the recording quality.

The songs we used for the testing

included a heavy bass file, a flange and bass track, Hotel California by the Eagles, and two Hindi tracks, Anjaane by Strings and Tanha Dil by Shaan. Both tracks are guitar-heavy, with extremely well-laid out vocals.

A real world test was also done, in which files amounting to 100 MB were transferred from computer to player, and the time taken was recorded. In the case of microdrive and hard drive-based players, we transferred 1 GB of music to gauge data transfer speeds.

The battery test was important. Amazingly, some players surpassed their rated times by good margins. For the battery tests, we played all the songs in a loop and kept the “repeat all” option turned on, while the player’s display was turned on from time to time.